

DIVINE WISDOM

theosophy

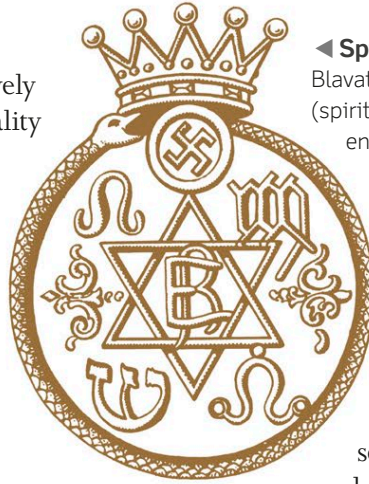
While the details of theosophy are complex, its basic tenet is comparatively simple—there is a single spiritual reality that can only be reached through deep contemplation, a power latent in all humans. Late 19th-century theosophy had much in common with other contemporary religious societies interested in magic, but it also incorporated Buddhist beliefs. It epitomized the era's fascination with the occult and was hugely influential, bringing Eastern ideas to the West and spawning hundreds of like-minded movements.

Core belief in universality

The Theosophical Society was founded in New York in 1875 by a Russian emigree, Helena Blavatsky. In 1879, Blavatsky went to India and three years later she transferred the headquarters of the burgeoning organization there. At the same time, a branch opened in London, and further branches followed across Europe and the US. The rich blend

▼ Headquarters in India

Helena Blavatsky set up the headquarters of the Theosophical Society in Adyar in southeast India around 1882, where it was well placed for the study and comparison of religions.



◀ Spiritual symbolism

Blavatsky's brooch had her initials in a hexagram (spirit and matter intertwined) under a swastika, enclosed by an *ouroboros*, a symbol of infinity.

of ideas from the East and West reinforced the theosophical creed of unity—there is a universality that binds humanity and infuses a higher understanding of who and what people are. Theosophy was a search for an absolute truth, timeless and infinite, or in Blavatsky's words, “a sense of being part of all that is.”

In 1885, the London Society for Psychical Research sensationally accused Blavatsky of being a fraud, a charge that ended her association with the movement. Theosophy continued to thrive, however, under the new direction of feminist and champion of Indian nationalism Annie Besant. It still flourishes in the 21st century, especially in Europe and the US. Its core beliefs remain unchanged—that all life is interconnected and continuous; that human existence can only be understood through intense study of the occult and its ritual practices in order to reach a state of higher consciousness; and that the ultimate goal, guided by truth, is a state of wholeness. There is no one path, but there is always only one goal.



▲ Helena Blavatsky

A charismatic Russian-born American theosophist, Blavatsky was hailed as a spiritual leader although her critics denounced her as a charlatan. She became a recluse and spent her final years in contemplative solitude in London.

